began to take root, although in a rather different sense than the modern use of it would imply. It is important to understand that, in the early Middle Ages up until the twelfth or even the thirteenth century, there was nothing 'Eastern' (meaning 'lesser') about the Byzantine Empire. Quite the contrary: the world then was Byzantium-centric. Europe's periphery was defined in relation to the Byzantine Empire, and it was Charlemagne and the popes who were trying hard to change this, first by the use of titles and language and then by *realpolitik*. It was only after about 1000 AD that Byzantium began slowly to decline, mainly because of its problems with the Arabs and later with the Ottomans. However, the association of Byzantium with bad government is mostly an invention. There is nothing in its history to suggest that 'standards in public office' in Byzantium were any lower than those in contemporary Western Europe. It is, therefore, erroneous to cite the Byzantine origins of Eastern Europe as a contributing factor to the relative backwardness of Eastern Europe in later centuries.

What was different – as already suggested – was the relationship between the Church and the State. In the West, worldly rulers were busy thinking about how they could use the Church for their own political purposes. On the other hand, the Church, although it was eager to influence politics and even ran its own state, was busy fighting for its own independence, in particular in ecclesiastical nominations and on property. From today's perspective, it may seem that in the past the Church ruled the West, hand-in-hand with the secular powers. But this was only really true where and when it suited the latter and, despite many exceptions to the rule, the ideal of the separation of the clerical and the secular spheres of activity is intrinsic to Western Christianity. When the Church in the West interfered with politics, it tried to do so on its own terms. It did not allow secular rulers to deal with theological issues. This was not the same in the Orthodox world where there was no attempt to conceal the unity of the two powers, sacred and secular. In fact, this unity was promoted and seen as a virtue, not primarily as an opportunity for political manipulation. Many rulers were genuinely concerned about theological issues and regarded themselves in the first instance as defenders of the faith. They also sincerely believed that the Christian God would punish them and destroy their earthly power if they did not uphold the true (Orthodox) Christian faith and lead their subjects to Him. Christianity was more important than the State. Of course, this is a